

be put out of service, the three major space agencies in the world – Soviet Space Programme, NASA and ESA – collectively turned their gaze to the Mir space station that the Soviets were planning.

Launched on February 26, 1986, Mir endured 15 years in orbit, three times its planned lifetime. In fact, it outlasted the Soviet Union that launched it into space! Mir translates into English as “world,” “peace,” and “village”. This would also be the first ‘modular’ space station as opposed the ‘monolithic’ approach of the Salyut and the Skylab.

Over the course of its 15 years in space, Mir hosted 125 cosmonauts and astronauts from 12 different nations. It supported 17 space expeditions, including 28 long-term crews. It raised the first crop of wheat to be grown from seed to seed in outer space.

In 2001, it was decided that Mir had reached the end of its useful life.



Russia's Mir space station is backdropped over the blue and white planet Earth in this medium range photograph recorded during the final fly-around of the members of the fleet of NASA's shuttles.